REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 01



AI Stalemate

THE LEAD DEVELOPER FIELD GUIDE

Make your judgment count. Shape responsible use with your PM.

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For you, the lead developer

OPEN YOUR LEAD DEVELOPER LAB >

UNDERSTAND THE PRESSURE. WORK THE SITUATION. LEAVE WITH A MOVE.

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Your PM sees potential. You own what ships.

Your PM wants the team to use AI. You may see promise, but you also see the verification, review, and maintenance it creates. This is a way to make your judgment useful and help shape the opportunity.

Get specific about the outcome

Ask your PM what they want to improve for customers or the team. Is the problem a customer wait, repeated work, missed learning, or constrained capacity? A clear outcome gives you something to evaluate.

Name the cost you actually carry

Point to the work or risk in this use: acceptance checks, missing codebase context, data boundaries, reviewer effort, or maintenance. Make your concern concrete enough to change the proposal.

Check your story about the request

Your PM asked for a trial by Friday. That is an event. They do not care about quality is an interpretation. Ask what is driving the request before treating your interpretation as their intent.

Help author the approach

Try: I can see why that outcome matters. Here is the use I would consider, the quality bar I would keep, and the capacity we would need. Your technical judgment can shape a better proposal.

> Your win: help the team learn where AI earns its place, protect the standards you own, and make a decision others can trust.

Paint a future worth working toward.

Get clear about the future you would want to help build. You can lead responsible adoption by connecting engineering judgment to a customer and team outcome your PM cares about.

Name the improvement you care about

Which improvement would be worth your engineering attention? Less repetitive work, more time for design, faster reliable feedback, or practices other developers can trust? Say why you would invest in it.

Paint a recognizable before and after

Describe the future in everyday work: shorter customer waits, fewer repetitive tasks, more time for judgment, or patterns other teams can trust. Make the picture specific enough to question and improve.

Connect it to a shared stake

The company could gain a useful capability. The team could gain mastery and influence over its standards. Building something others trust could also create professional opportunities for both leaders.

Invite authorship

Ask your PM: Which outcome matters most? What would you change in this picture? Co-author the ambition and ask them to help protect the time needed to pursue it responsibly.

Connect the picture to the next move

A vision gives the work direction. The next move makes it credible: clarify a concern, resolve permission or capacity, use existing evidence, or agree on one bounded test.

> Try: I'd like us to find the uses that actually improve accepted work. If we can make those practices trustworthy, we could help set the company's standard and give our team more room for the hard problems. That could create opportunities for both of us. Which outcome would make this worth pursuing from your side?

Make the concern workable.

Make your concerns useful to the PM. Describe where the proposed use breaks down, what condition could make it workable, or why the evidence already supports stopping. Ask for the priority tradeoff when capacity is the issue.

The quality is not good enough

Which checks or standards fail? Consider a smaller task, clearer acceptance criteria, repository conventions, automated tests, and human review. Keep the existing quality bar.

Reviewing it takes longer

Where does effort increase? Consider smaller changes, explicit author verification, and protected review time. Measure accepted work across the whole workflow rather than the first draft.

Our data or code cannot go into that tool

Which inputs and approvals are involved? Establish the permitted tool and input boundary with the approval owner. Synthetic or non-sensitive inputs may be an option; permission comes first.

It does not understand our codebase

Which context or conventions are missing? Consider explicit repository instructions, a known example, and a contained task. Check whether the available context actually supports that use.

We do not have capacity

What work would this replace, and who must review it? Ask the priority owner to protect time or decline the investment. Unplanned overtime is not the trial budget.

We tried it and it was worse

Which task, conditions, and result? Use that evidence. If a materially different use is proposed, name what changed and why another test would answer a useful question.

GitHub: Copilot best practices

Thoughtworks: reducing AI development friction

> The useful question is: Which condition would make this proposal workable, and who can decide it? Keep a specific no and an unsupported yes open to the same scrutiny.

Let's get ready to talk with your PM.

Take 5-10 minutes before you meet your PM. Write the specific work you would protect, the outcome you could support, and what evidence would change your view.

What did your PM ask for, and what happened?

Use the request, words, or event you can describe. Be precise enough that the other person could recognize it.

What are you assuming about your PM's motives?

Name your interpretation of their motive. Hold it as a hypothesis rather than a fact.

What quality, review, or maintenance responsibility are you protecting?

Describe the opportunity, cost, obligation, or outcome you carry. Product and Engineering can both have legitimate answers.

What have you observed in the actual workflow?

Separate a concrete past result from a prediction about future use. An observed failure deserves attention; it does not settle every use case.

What evidence would change your assessment of this use?

Name the evidence that could alter your view. A trial is not useful if neither side would reconsider anything.

What do you need to ask your PM about the outcome or priority?

Leave room for their actual account of the cost. Do not turn private preparation into a better argument for your original position.

> The Lab excludes every private-preparation field from the Trial Card, Evidence Record, and Decision Brief.

One test you could both believe.

Spend about 30 minutes with your PM shaping one test you could trust. You bring technical suitability and acceptance checks; your PM helps clarify the outcome and the priority tradeoff.

Agree on the ambition

Share the future you hope to help create and why it matters. Ask the other leader to shape it. Record only the ambition you both agree to pursue in shared work.

Bound the work

Name the work outcome, exact task, and work that is out of scope. Choose a comparator without AI and say why the task size, experience, and acceptance bar are comparable.

Set the permission boundary

Confirm the approved tool, model/version, allowed inputs, and approval owner. If permission is missing, name exactly what must be resolved before work can start.

Protect quality and capacity

Define the acceptance checks and accountable engineering owner. Estimate and protect author and reviewer time. Ask your PM to make the displaced work visible to the priority owner.

Agree on the bar beforehand

Define success across the full workflow, not just generation speed. Write a stop rule that can be acted on during the trial.

Make ownership explicit

Name the task owner, reviewer, decision owner, and review date. Export the Trial Card now, before the test. If a prerequisite is missing, name it and choose PAUSE.

> A good trial: one approved unit-test task with comparable work and reserved review time. A weak trial: Everyone use AI this week and report whether it felt faster.

Count the work on both sides.

Record the work you and the reviewer actually do, including checks, rework, and later defects. Give your PM a full picture of cost and quality that they can responsibly communicate.

Workflow stage	Without AI	With AI
Setup / context	10 min	15 min
Drafting	45 min	12 min
Author verification	15 min	25 min
Reviewer checking	15 min	30 min
Rework	5 min	15 min
Follow-up	0 min	0 min
Total person-minutes	**90 min**	**97 min**

The worked example

These fictional measurements describe one matched unit-test task. The acceptance bar passed after rework. Drafting was faster with AI, while verification, review, and rework increased.

What the totals establish

Drafting took 33 fewer minutes, but the full recorded workflow took 7 more. Reviewer checking increased by 15 minutes. The agreed effort bar was missed in this local test.

What remains outside the totals

Record acceptance checks, defects, reviewer experience, tool cost, elapsed time, first-use learning, and limits to comparability. Name an owner and date for a later defect check.

> A complete total is useful evidence. It is not a universal AI productivity claim, a quality verdict, or proof of causation.

Four legitimate next moves.

Review the evidence with your PM and the agreed decision owner. Be specific about what this use supports, what would need to change, and when another test would be worthwhile.

CONTINUE

The evidence supports this bounded use under these conditions. Record the operating boundaries and the next review. Continue does not mean AI everywhere.

REVISE

The use may have value, but the task, inputs, review workflow, or boundaries need to change. Name what will change before another approved trial.

STOP

The evidence does not support this use, or a guardrail was breached. Record why and preserve what was learned. There is no obligation to turn a failed use case into adoption.

PAUSE

A prerequisite, approval, owner, capacity, or useful evidence is missing. Name the prerequisite and who will resolve it. Pause can be chosen before a trial starts.

> Every decision needs a reason, the limits of the evidence, an accountable next-action owner, and a date. Record unresolved disagreement rather than claiming consensus.

From an argument to a defensible move.

Here is a decision you and your PM can both defend. AI drafted faster, but verification and review increased. Your observations changed the approach and gave leadership a concrete next move.

The Trial Card

Outcome: reduce the effort of producing accepted unit tests. Task: one isolated unit-test task; production code and customer data are out of scope. Use an approved tool with synthetic fixtures and a recorded version.

The shared bar

Preserve the existing test review and CI checks. Reserve author and reviewer time. Success requires lower total effort without transferring additional checking to the reviewer. Stop for unapproved inputs or a failed quality guardrail.

The Evidence Record

Without AI: 90 person-minutes. With AI: 97. The quality bar passed after rework, but reviewer checking doubled from 15 to 30 minutes. One local task does not establish a general gain or loss.

The Decision Brief

REVISE. The current workflow transfers too much work to review. The engineering lead will narrow the task and review workflow before approving another trial, with a named review date.

The update to leadership

Our first test passed quality after rework but used 97 person-minutes versus 90 without AI. We are revising the review workflow before testing again.

> They did not leave with agreement about AI in general. They left with a specific decision, its evidence, and a next action.

Take this into the work.

Use this Guide to prepare your judgment, then open your Lead Developer Lab to work your actual situation. Nic's walkthrough demonstrates the same method on a realistic case.

1. Prepare privately

Open Private Prep in the Lead Developer Lab. Write the event, the cost you carry, your Why, the future you could help create, and what you still need to ask your PM.

2. Build and export the Trial Card

Move to Shared Work. Agree on the task, comparator, permission, quality, capacity, bar, stop rule, owners, and review date. Export the Trial Card before the test.

3. Return with evidence

Enter full-workflow effort for both methods, quality results, and comparison limits. Export the Evidence Record. Blank effort stays unknown.

4. Write the decision

Choose Continue, Revise, Stop, or Pause. Name the reason, limits, next action, owner, date, and leadership update. Copy, download, or print the Decision Brief.

Keep what matters

Drafts live in this browser on this device. Export important work before clearing browser data or changing devices. There is no cloud backup or synchronized team workspace in this edition.

> Want to rehearse first? Watch Nic work through a complete case, then load the fictional example in the Lab before bringing your own situation.